

Why Did the U.S. Enter World War I?

Weigh the evidence for why the United States abandoned neutrality and entered World War I in 1917 — and decide which cause mattered most.

? Historical challenge

For nearly three years the United States stayed neutral in World War I. Then, in the spring of 1917, it declared war on Germany. Historians agree on the sequence of events but disagree about which cause weighed most. Weigh the evidence, note what conflicts and what is missing, and build a defensible working conclusion.

1 Investigate

SOURCES 1

Zimmermann Telegram (Milestone Documents) – National Archives

PRIMARY SOURCE

The decoded German proposal of a Mexico–Germany alliance.

[Open source ↗](#)

Investigate:

- What did the telegram propose?
- Why would it inflame American opinion?

SOURCES 2

Wilson Before Congress – Library of Congress

PRIMARY SOURCE

Wilson's April 1917 war message and the close vote that followed.

[Open source ↗](#)

Investigate:

- How does Wilson justify going to war?
- What might a persuasive speech leave out?

SOURCES 3

American Entry into World War I, 1917 – Office of the Historian (State Dept.)

SECONDARY SOURCE

A balanced overview of the converging causes of U.S. entry.

[Open source ↗](#)

Investigate:

- Which causes does this source list?
- How does it help you weigh the evidence?

2 Build your Event Map

Fill in the organizer from the evidence. Mark information with ①②③ to show which source it came from. Leave a space blank if the sources don't tell you.

Historical question

Why did the United States enter World War I in 1917 — and which cause mattered most?

What we think we know

The U.S. was officially neutral from 1914 until it declared war on April 6, 1917. Two events in early 1917 immediately preceded the declaration: Germany's resumption of unrestricted submarine warfare (Feb. 1) and the publication of the Zimmermann Telegram (March 1). Wilson framed entry around both German aggression at sea and a larger ideological purpose.

1 Evidence 1

SOURCE

The Zimmermann Telegram (1917),
National Archives

PRIMARY OR SECONDARY?

Primary — decoded German
diplomatic cable

EVIDENCE

A coded German message
proposing a Mexico–Germany
alliance and the return of Texas,
New Mexico, and Arizona to Mexico
if the U.S. entered the war;
published in American newspapers
March 1, 1917.

2 Evidence 2

SOURCE

Wilson's War Message to Congress,
April 2, 1917

PRIMARY OR SECONDARY?

Primary — presidential speech

EVIDENCE

Wilson cited Germany's unrestricted
submarine warfare as 'warfare
against mankind' and asked
Congress to declare war to make
'the world safe for democracy.'

WHY IT MATTERS

3 Evidence 3

SOURCE

'American Entry into World War I' —
Office of the Historian, U.S. State
Dept.

PRIMARY OR SECONDARY?

Secondary — government overview

EVIDENCE

Synthesizes multiple causes —
submarine warfare, the
Zimmermann Telegram, U.S.
economic and financial ties to the
Allies, and public opinion.

WHY IT MATTERS

WHY IT MATTERS

Turned much of U.S. public and Congressional opinion against Germany by suggesting a direct threat to American territory, weeks before the war vote.

RELIABILITY / LIMITATION

Authentic and Zimmermann-confirmed, but it reached Americans via British intelligence, which wanted the U.S. in the war; the alliance was only a proposal, never acted on by Mexico.

The official public justification for entry, weighting both attacks on neutral shipping and an ideological **RELIABILITY / LIMITATION** mission for democracy.

A persuasive political speech meant to build support; it emphasizes moral and legal causes and downplays U.S. economic ties to the Allies.

Provides balanced context showing that no single factor acted alone, helping students weigh competing explanations.
RELIABILITY / LIMITATION

A reliable scholarly summary, but condensed; it interprets and prioritizes causes rather than presenting the underlying documents in full.

Conflicting evidence

Historians agree on what happened but weight causes differently: the submarine-warfare view sees the Feb. 1 resumption as the trigger; the Zimmermann-Telegram view stresses its effect on public opinion; the economic-ties view emphasizes U.S. loans and trade with the Allies; the ideology view highlights Wilson's 'safe for democracy' framing. The disagreement is about emphasis, not basic facts.

Missing evidence

Missing: quantified proof of how much economic ties actually drove the decision; Wilson's private deliberations; systematic public-opinion data (no modern polling); German internal decision-making; and the perspectives of the dissenters who voted no.

Working conclusion

One defensible interpretation: the U.S. entered because of causes that peaked in early 1917. Submarine warfare was the immediate trigger; the Zimmermann Telegram shifted public and Congressional opinion; longer-term economic ties and Wilson's ideology shaped how leaders responded. Reasonable historians weight these differently.

Sources 1

Sources 2

Sources 3

3 Compare

- Compare your evidence cards with a partner. Did you rate the same sources as reliable?
- Did you and your partner weight the same cause as most important? What evidence moved you?

4 Expand

Your teacher will add context, vocabulary, and information the sources leave out. Add it to your map.

TEACHER NOTE

Key ideas

This is a historiography exercise: students weigh multiple causes rather than find one 'right' answer. The immediate triggers (unrestricted submarine warfare; the Zimmermann Telegram) sit alongside longer-term factors (economic ties to the Allies; Wilson's ideology). Reliability and point of view matter: the Zimmermann Telegram reached Americans through British intelligence; Wilson's message is persuasive rhetoric. Do not quote document wording students have not read — describe and cite.

Common misconceptions

- The Lusitania (1915) did not by itself bring the U.S. into the war; entry came in 1917.
- A primary source is not automatically neutral — each source argues a position.
- There is no single agreed 'cause'; the debate is about weighting.

Vocabulary

neutrality, unrestricted submarine warfare, Zimmermann Telegram, containment of interpretation (historiography), isolationism, Fourteen Points.

Historical context

Neutrality 1914; Lusitania May 1915; Germany resumes unrestricted submarine warfare Feb. 1, 1917; Zimmermann Telegram published March 1, 1917; Wilson's war message April 2; Congress declares war April 6, 1917 (Senate 82–6, House 373–50).

5 Revise

Go back to your Event Map. Add, correct, or reorganize based on the discussion.

6 Conclude

Write a working conclusion answering why the U.S. entered World War I. Cite at least two evidence cards, acknowledge a competing interpretation, and note one limitation of your evidence.